

POST- WORK

Edited by
Stanley Aronowitz
and
Jonathan Cutler

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The Wages of Cybernation

edited by

Stanley Aronowitz

and

Jonathan Cutler

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■ Quitting Time

An Introduction

Jonathan Cutler and Stanley Aronowitz

Is the labor movement finished? Are predictions that U.S. unions are destined to represent no more than 5 percent of the U.S. labor force by the year 2000 accurate? Are recent statistics that show wages and salaries among non-union workers growing at a faster rate than those of union workers an anomaly, or do they indicate a long-term or even permanent reversal of the historic trend of union-driven income? As this book went to press the Teamsters' smashing victory against the United Parcel Service (UPS) seemed to belie such prognostications. For the first time since the concessions movement that followed the 1981 air traffic controllers' debacle, especially the Teamsters' UPS contract that established the two-tier system, Organized Labor launched an offensive to restore the all but lapsed principle of equal pay for equal work—and won. Needless to say, one victory does not a rejuvenated labor movement make, even as the AFL-CIO pledged \$10 million a week to supplement the depleted Teamster strike fund. It is too early to tell whether the encrusted habits of a generation of labor leaders will dissolve in the sunlight of the UPS strike. Indeed, contrary to conventional wisdom, which holds that unions grow in times of economic upswing, unions have made no substantial organizing or bargaining gains in the 1990s even though six years of this decade have seen sustained economic growth. While

union membership has remained roughly constant, the forty-five-year downward trend in union density (the proportion of union members to the labor force) has not been reversed despite a renewed determination by union leaders and rank-and-file activists to revive the labor movement. In fact, although some unions—notably the Service Employees and the Laborers—sustained aggressive organizing programs in the dismal 1980s, union spending on recruiting is, on the whole, still fairly small in comparison to the funds spent on administering contracts and insurance programs and maintaining union offices. Despite evidence that some efforts to change the proportions between organizing and service are being undertaken, unions still resemble insurance companies more than social movements. The full-time union official typically devotes the lion's share of her/his time to grievances and other membership services.

Nor has the nearly fifteen years of concession bargaining been reversed in any major contract. At best, union negotiators are pleased if they succeed in holding the line against further concessions or in making modest wage gains. For all intents and purposes, collective bargaining remains the religion of the labor movement only as a ritual performance. Almost invariably, workers continue to surrender hard-won protections and have not even made any innovative proposals at the bargaining table, let alone succeeded in winning any of the traditional demands for substantial wage increases and shorter hours.

In sum, economic indicators are no longer reliable predictors of trade union membership growth, workers' bargaining power, or the extension of unionism to hitherto unorganized sectors. For example, labor's decline in all of these areas—and its declining social and political influence—(in 1997 a newly reelected President Clinton did not even choose the AFL-CIO's preferred candidate for Secretary of Labor), seems relatively impervious to the six-year economic upturn. Longer term and deeper causes must be at work in the continuing slide.

Organized labor's fate seems precarious, and yet it is not clear what ails it. The cure, should one exist, will not come without a clear diagnosis of the disease. The central prob-

lem is to identify the *sources of strategic power* which are available to the labor movement. Among these sources none ranks higher than the revival of a militant rank and file prepared to fight against capital's nearly quarter-century assault on labor's postwar gains. For the days when unions as veritable insurance companies were able to negotiate for their members without more than sporadic mobilization, especially around contract time, seem definitely over. In the wake of capital's globalization, which has given employers new weapons against unionized workers such as outsourcing, the runaway shop, the ability to recruit replacement workers for strikers, and a Democratic president willing to use antilabor legislation to delay strikes and weaken unions, union leaders still hesitate to intervene aggressively to protect labor's positions. Many unions have become leadership cabals that, at best, are service providers to individuals and, at worst, self-enclosed bureaucracies. In many instances the union offices and halls are empty of rank-and-file members, except when individuals or groups have specific grievances or, as is the case of many locals in large cities, the union offers services such as legal and benefits assistance, English classes for foreign-born members and their families, or medical clinics. Their capacity and will to mobilize members have been severely tested since President Ronald Reagan's firing of 11,000 air traffic controllers, and both have been found wanting.

Others have suggested that the major ill is that many unions are no longer, if they ever were, democratic organizations. Some unions are downright corrupt. The recent contest between Teamster president Ron Carey and challenger James P. Hoffa, the son of the iconic former leader of the union, was conducted on this issue. The one-term incumbent Carey claimed that during his five years in office he had begun the long journey from Mob control to clean, democratic unionism and accused his opponent of getting into bed with the old-time, corrupt union barons who still controlled many locals and district councils. Hoffa accused the Carey administration of watering down the once feared bargaining power of the union and of arbitrarily and undemocratically taking over allegedly corrupt union locals. He promised to

restore the union to its once militant and powerful position. In an election in which half the union's 1.2 million members voted, Carey won the election by a slim, 16,000-vote majority. In the end, Hoffa's message got through to nearly half the voters, many of whom remained unimpressed by Carey's anti-corruption message; they evaluated union performance by its shop-floor and organizing record and found it wanting. Ironically, labor insiders credit Carey's support with the victory of John Sweeney's insurgent slate for AFL-CIO leadership, which promised to reverse the years of labor's decline by aggressive organizing and political action. However, in his first five-year term the Teamsters were consumed by internal reform, did their share of concession bargaining, and did not display the old vaunted power that once sent tremors through employers' hearts. That power, we may add, was wielded by a string of leaders whose ties to the Mob and other traditional sources of union corruption were legendary. Jimmy Hoffa, father of the recent challenger, might have had questionable morality but, in terms of militancy, he compared favorably with most clean leaders.

But while blatant corruption can be shown to be a problem confined to fairly few industries, most of which are associated with services where the Mob has as much power among employers as unions, some observers focus on a problem whose symptoms may be described as a different type of corruption: labor oligarchy. This view stresses the power of the relatively honest labor bureaucracy over union affairs; local unions, the closest institutions to the rank and file, are typically subordinated to the control of international unions who have centralized many, if not most, union functions. In contrast to the highly visible, membership-based vote for top officials in the Teamsters, the vast majority of national union leaders are elected by indirect means, by delegates to a convention rather than by the rank and file. (In fact, the direct election in the Teamsters Union was the result of a court order rather than by a provision of the union's constitution or bylaws.) Perhaps more to the point, most unions at all levels are typically administered by full-time officials who, with some exceptions, tend to regard the membership as a collective client which needs to be con-

trolled lest the economic and political position of the union be undermined by rank-and-file recalcitrance. The formation of a permanent labor bureaucracy becomes, in this view, the sufficient explanation for poor organizing performance, the demobilization of the rank and file in the wake of the corporate offensive against labor's historical gains and the palatable unpopularity of organized labor among the general population, a deficit which inhibits labor's chances to convince Congress and the state legislatures to enact its programs and also inhibits building public support for strikes and organizing campaigns. Plainly, if the rank and file is disempowered by undemocratic union practices, they are not likely to respond favorably to eleventh-hour appeals by leaders they have come to distrust if not despise.

Another explanation for labor's decline points to the prevailing unfavorable economic, political, and cultural climate that has afflicted working people for the last quarter-century. Accordingly, labor is held *virtually* blameless for its shrinking membership and declining power. The main culprits, in this view, are the transnational corporations and the emergent global economy they control. Transnational capital has surely placed labor in competition with itself on a world scale, but labor movements remain largely imprisoned by national borders and parochial politics and culture. This mode of explanation talks eloquently of the runaway shop, of labor-destroying technologies, the reemergence of those nineteenth- and early twentieth-century practices of child labor and homework, of a labor-relations law that works overtime to restrict Labor's ability to organize and, in the main, has reduced collective bargaining to trench warfare. It explains union acquiescence to employer demands for "cooperation" by the threat that if they don't go along they will lose everything. Advocates of this view remind us of the Taft-Hartley amendments to the labor relations law, especially the provisions that permit employers to replace strikers with non-union workers, enable employers to procure court injunctions against mass picketing, and impose huge fines against unions that sanction strikes during the life of contracts (almost all of which contain a strike prohibition). But it can be shown that unions have chosen to

work within adverse labor relations laws because they have determined a bad law is better than none. Having no law would subject unions to the prevailing laws of capitalism: competition and the marketplace. Unions would be required to *strike* for higher wages, shorter hours, and other benefits. And for many union leaders, especially in the public sector (now a major segment of the American labor movement), the strike weapon has been virtually renounced in return for collective bargaining. Perhaps collective bargaining and labor relations laws were a Faustian bargain. This bargain may help explain why unions have been reluctant to challenge their political allies to enact labor law reform, much less choose confrontational tactics to advance labor's demands.

For some time, social movement theorists have identified the *mobilization of resources* as the key to movement success (see especially Shorter and Tilly 1974; Tilly 1978; Zald and McCarthy 1987). There are generic problems associated with the resource mobilization perspective. For example, while there is almost certainly some correlation between resource accumulation, institutionalization, and bureaucratization, on the one hand, and movement power, on the other, it is not clear whether resource mobilization is a cause or an effect (McAdam 1983). It may well be that resources, institutional forms, and bureaucracies tend to *follow* the scent of movement energy rather than *providing* the gas necessary for its combustion.¹ Nevertheless, while a lack of resources may well plague the spirits of many activists,² this cannot be said of those in the labor movement. Machiavelli, if asked by the Princes of the labor movement for strategic advice, would be laughed out of the royal court for suggesting that a failure to effectively *mobilize resources* was the root of labor's troubles.

The labor movement has been in a serious crisis for some time now, unable to win significant victories. And yet, the problem simply *cannot* be said to be attributable to a lack of means. There is no shortage of institutionalization within the contemporary labor movement. The instrument, that is to say the bureaucracy, has been called many things, but underdeveloped is not one of them. The appearance of this

fissure between feats of resource mobilization and defeats of movement power is entirely unexpected, not simply from the perspective of the theorists of resource mobilization, but from the perspective of contemporary witnesses present at the birth of the postwar labor movement (Mills 1948). And yet, during the period immediately after World War II, when Big Labor was at the zenith of its institutional intensity and the crest of its resource riches, it faced some of its most infamous upsets.³ Some labor historians today are in a mad rush backward in time, each uncovering significant losses that, they argue, were actually the beginning of the end for the postwar labor movement. Each historian fixes the first moment of decline closer and closer to the birth. And yet, in so doing, *none* of these historians have ever thought of attributing the decline to a lack of resources.⁴

The importance of resource mobilization (especially in terms of fiscal resources) must be considered alongside other movement factors. As Klandermans (1984) argued, this involves a shift in the notion of what constitutes a resource, and most of the redefinition has been toward cultural and ideological resources as strategically significant variables.⁵ It may prove critical to understanding the fate of social movement for analysts to understand the way a movement strategically frames its *constituencies*, *grievances*, *plans*, *expectations*, and *visions*. Indeed, more recent emphasis within social movement literature has been to appreciate the importance of “framing” and discourse, and this is surely a salutary development for anyone wishing to understand the fate of the labor movement (for discussions of “framing” which consider cases from labor history, see Babb 1996; Clemens 1996; Klandermans 1984; Voss 1993; Voss 1996).

The significant theoretic innovation is not based in the “discovery” that the ideational realm is “socially constructed.” The point of emphasizing the existence of strategic logics is not to argue that these are “automatic” logics, but to notice *how many* different logics are always “available” to the labor movement and *how influential* these logics can be on the fate of the labor movement. Some are clearly more sustainable than others. Our task, then, is to elaborate some of the significant logics available from

within the repertoire of labor history. We are particularly interested in their sustainability.⁶ One analytic tool which may be helpful in mapping the various strategic logics of the labor movement is to look at labor movement strategies as efforts to achieve power by creating a “tightness” between the supply of their labor and the demand for it on the market.⁷ As Marx noted, such market tightness dramatically and decisively strengthens labor and its *pretensions*, while the existence of a large supply of labor in excess of the demand for labor undermines labor’s power (Marx 1976, 792).⁸ Labor’s power derives from the inability of employers to replace pretentious workers with workers willing to settle for less. It is possible, based on this labor market model, to begin to identify a few of the multiplicity of strategic logics available to the labor movement in its attempts to keep labor markets tight. The labor market model immediately opens up two distinct strategic pathways: increasing the demand for labor and/or diminishing its supply. The former is associated with the corporatist tradition of the labor movement while the latter path is associated with the syndicalist tradition.

The trade union emerged as a syndicalist effort to diminish the supply of labor on the market by exploiting the skill requirements common to many pre-industrial labor processes. The labor process, and its basis in skilled work, did not create craft unions. The demand for skill simply divided the labor market *analytically* and implied no necessary flow of power relations. The demand for skilled labor does not, in itself, determine the supply of skilled labor, nor does it mean that all skilled laborers are powerfully positioned within the labor market. The labor market respects supply and demand, not skill; a market flooded with skilled workers is no different—in terms of power flows in market relations—than a market flooded with unskilled workers, even if production is dependent on skilled labor (Tilly 1988).⁹ To the degree that there is a greater supply of skilled labor than demand for it, so too, to this degree are skilled workers likely to enter into a bidding war which devolves toward desperation and despair. One way of limiting the supply of laborers delivered to the labor market is to *mark* a piece of

the job market—the sub-set of the market which depends on skilled workers—and restrict access to skills required for these jobs.

This is the basis of the craft union movement. Members of a trade union then are able to *trade* on their skills from a strong bargaining position. One central question, then, for *all* movements seeking to accomplish this form of restriction is how to *mark* a portion of the population “deserving” of access, and how to keep the rest of the population from acquiring these skills. The establishment of the “training apparatus” itself is not the difficult political struggle. Rather, the question becomes one of negotiating *who* will learn the skills, and *who will be excluded* from learning skills. The problem, to borrow a phrase from Benedict Anderson, is the creation of “imagined communities” or *the creation of identities and exclusions* which keep the skilled labor supply limited (Anderson 1983; Mink 1986). Who will become an apprentice? Who will be excluded from learning these “secret” skills? While exclusions are *essential* to this process, and not merely epiphenomenal, the power of those who have become skilled remains a consequence of the ratio of demand for skilled labor to the supply of skilled labor, and not the ratio of skilled labor to unskilled labor. Nevertheless, exclusivity remains absolutely and permanently essential to the logic of the “craft.” To *criticize* the tendency of the old craft unions for their failure to “organize the unorganized” is either to completely misunderstand the logic of craft unionism or to call for its abolition. The constituency of a craft labor movement must be *exclusive*. For the movement *in general* it does not matter *which* criteria are used for selection, so long as the criteria are differential; and it doesn’t matter *who* is excluded, so long as the labor market proportions are right when it is all over.

Of course, the great weaknesses of this strategy are now well known, especially to employers. The first threat to skill-based power is the difficulty, for those members already inside a craft-based labor movement, of maintaining exclusive control of the “secrets” of the craft. Knowledge is notoriously troublesome as private property because, unlike other properties, it is not lost by an owner when seized by a

thief.¹⁰ By acquiring knowledge and skill without the consent of the trade union, the excluded can effectively undermine the basis of their exclusion. Similarly, struggles for “open admissions” to the institutions which control labor market skills are struggles for the end of skill as a strategic logic of exclusion within the labor movement. The other great vulnerability of a craft labor movement is the success of employers in their struggles to de-skill the labor process (Braverman 1974; Montgomery 1979). This is undertaken by employers to destroy their dependence on the exclusive sub-set of skilled workers and therefore to be able draw on the larger, and presumably unfettered, supply of labor provided by the larger population.

While skill served as the analytic basis for the strategy of exclusion behind craft unionism, the logic of labor market exclusion may transcend skill. Any differential mechanism of exclusion can potentially be used to reduce the supply of laborers to the labor market or to a niche within the labor market. This strategy, accomplished with more or less success in term of sustainability, depends in large measure on the ability of the *imagined community* to capture the imagination of the community at large. It does not depend on skill; skill can drop out altogether. Indeed, the list of identities which have been, or continue to be, invoked as restrictive criteria is astonishingly long. However, it is worth identifying some of the major (and often overlapping) “imagined communities.” Almost all of these identity-based exclusions have been adopted as strategic logics, at one time or another, within the major American craft unions and the American Federation of Labor (AFL) as a whole. Many continue to serve as effective ideological strategies in other institutional settings, and quite a few survive without any of the resources mobilized by *formal* institutional backing. Skilled craftsmen have mobilized as groups against those outside the membership (Fraser 1991; Yellowitz 1977). Age has served as the basis for solidarities of exclusion in several ways. Within particular firms, senior workers have imagined themselves as a worthy community with labor market primacy in relation to newer workers (Lichtenstein 1988). In the larger labor market, “middle-aged” workers have been “empowered” through the with-

drawal of elder workers (retirement) and child laborers (Graebner 1980; Nasaw 1985). "Whiteness" and the ideology of its supremacy has functioned extremely well to justify the exclusion of people "of color" (Roediger 1991). National, ethnic, and religious identities have been remarkably successful as the basis for excluding other national identities (Mink 1986). Moreover, the long and continuing history of efforts by men to keep women from supplying labor to the labor market falls within the category of labor movement efforts at market tightening (Gabin 1991).¹¹ All of these strategies can survive only so long as the excluded do not effectively contest their exclusion. Exclusions from particular sectors of the labor market usually imply lower subsistence levels relative to those who work in such sectors. However, exclusions from the labor market do not necessarily translate into exclusions from subsistence altogether; this would be altogether unsustainable.¹² The logic behind the exclusion of women and children from the labor market has always implied that the family was the most fundamental unit of income sharing and labor supply regulation. However, not only did this create well-known difficulties for orphans, but it also *bound* women and children to the family, and to a man whose market bargaining position was the sole source of market power. Indeed, the problem of being *excluded from sacrificing years of life in return for a wage* would seem to be no problem at all, were it not for this dangerous *binding* involved.

The problems associated with the exclusivity of craft unionism, and more generally, of divisiveness within the working class, were quite familiar to many observers of the early craft union tradition. What is the basis of an alternative logic? It must be noted, first of all, that the *interest* in "industrial unionism" and the fate of the excluded, relatively powerless segments of the working class has been enormous. We would argue that this has been due less to the arrival of a clear alternative logic than to enormous waves of anxiety arising from the many historic failures of the craft union logic and other forms of exclusivism to effectively come to terms with the excluded masses of the population, including immigrants, the unskilled, the unemployed, the elderly, the national, ethnic, and religious

subaltern, women, and children. Those committed to moral crusades on behalf of the subaltern and those committed to leading "revolutions" among the industrial working class have been passionately *interested in and committed to* these constituencies. Moreover, significant numbers of those whose exclusive labor market positions look increasingly threatened by these constituencies have been committed to finding ways of avoiding a swift decline into indigence (Hanagan 1988). The Knights of Labor and the Congress of Industrial Organizations (CIO), for example, were both efforts by such concerned craft unionists, looking for a new strategic logic.

So what else is there? Plenty of actual industrial unionism, but with surprisingly little articulation of a clear strategic logic. In the early years of industrial unionism, it may have seemed like nit-picking to notice this; a bit like asking, "O.K., it works in practice, but does it work in theory?" However, it must be noted that the rise of industrial unionism, and particularly the successes of the CIO, occurred during years of extraordinary turmoil. Significantly, the inspiration for industrial unionism emerged from economic crisis and war (especially World War I and the Depression), but its power was not realized until the beginning of the largest wartime mobilization in history (Fraser 1991; Lichtenstein 1982).

Depression-era industrial unionism, especially during the early months of 1937, may have at first been based less on a labor market strategy than on a strategy of workplace action, combined with the threat of violence, during a capitalist crisis of popular legitimation. One might argue that the famous sit-down strikes represent an actual incipient strategic logic. This logic was not based on a labor market strategy but, instead, on the enhanced workplace costs which workers could impose on business in industries with high fixed capital investments (Tilly 1988). In fact it might be argued that the factory occupations were *alternatives* to a labor market strategy. Since relatively unskilled industrial workers are easily replaced, their power resides in preventing similarly deskilled or unskilled labor from replacing them, which under conditions of a surfeit of unemployed labor was best achieved not by

picketing or otherwise withholding their labor but by seizing the production site. Any work stoppage is immediately more costly to capital-intensive industries. The occupation of facilities during the sit-down strikes dramatically increased the threat to investments, as workers held the plant itself hostage. These seizures depended, in turn, on the often-noted unwillingness of political elites to protect GM property by storming plants and risking violent confrontation during a period of general economic and political crisis (Fine 1969; Kraus 1985). However, sit-down tactics never emerged as an actual strategic tendency. By all accounts, postwar industrial unionism marked a decline in the role of workplace-based strategies for preserving power. In the capital-intensive industries employers sought to prevent any kind of work stoppage that might destroy machinery. Rather, extended no-strike pledges during long contract periods signified a strategy of labor-management cooperation (Lichtenstein 1995). Moreover, it is questionable whether the drama of the sit-down strike was a sustainable strategic source of power so much as it was an expression of power. The basis of this power was not in a strategic logic, but in the mid-Depression rise in production, employment, and labor market tightness. In the economic downturn which followed the sit-downs in 1937, the industrial unions, left with no autonomous strategy apart from exogenously determined labor market conditions, faced a crisis of confidence and power.

Industrial unionism ultimately found success in a tight labor market created not by a relative withdrawal of labor supply, but a dramatic increase in the demand for labor brought on by the needs of wartime production. In this context, workers were willing to fight for the satisfaction of many different demands, and the resolution of many grievances. The pretension of the rank-and-file industrial workers was enormous, with relatively unskilled production workers participating in wildcat strikes over a range of grievances and demands, large and small. The first round of postwar collective bargaining was the occasion for the largest strike wave in American history, as workers threw off the burdens of wartime sacrifice and exercised their labor market power in a climate of heightened labor demand.

Workers knew the power of the hand they were dealt, and they played their cards enthusiastically (Glaberman 1980).

It is only at this time that men like Sidney Hillman, one of the leading ideologues of industrial unionism, emerged as C. Wright Mills's (1948) New Men of Power. But ironically, these labor leaders became important to industry leaders, politicians, and the military at this time precisely because the rank and file had begun to use its new power, created by wartime production. When Sidney Hillman addressed himself to questions of labor supply, he did so during a time of labor shortage. Moreover, his concern was to *facilitate* widespread training and manpower development *against* the protests of the trade unions (Fraser 1991). From this perspective, the strategic logic of industrial unionism was for the enhancement of the prestige, as responsible labor statesmen, of leaders like Hillman, Murray, and Reuther who committed themselves to the effort of taming the labor market pretensions of the rank and file.

As the war came to an end, Walter Reuther, the innovator and acknowledged strategic leader of the postwar industrial union movement, came out strongly in support of the job-creation strategies which comprise the corporatist strategic logic of increased demand for labor. In the wartime boom, industrial unionists had learned the benefits of tight labor markets based on elevated demand. They would spend the postwar decades trying desperately to recreate these heady days of labor's power and prestige. One such effort has been based on the idea, promoted vigorously by economist and official in the Truman administration Leon Keyeserling, that the *government* should be the employer of last resort or that, in a more Keynesian mode, government purchasing of goods and services should be used to enhance consumption, then production, and finally, labor demand. In practice this has meant that the industrial labor movement becomes ideologically committed to promoting the benefits of government spending (and thus, either borrowing or taxing) on "public" goods, the production of which would not compete with private sector industries (and, more to the point, private sector jobs). Accordingly, in the logic of this Keynesian strategy, industrial unions would

be indifferent to the actually nature of the “goods” to be produced. At UAW conventions after the war, Reuther spoke frequently of the need for the government to increase spending on housing, schools, highways, etc. His many pronouncements to this effect aligned him, in the public mind, with the idea that industrial unionism meant not simply tight labor markets, but also “social unionism” based on concerns for the well-being of the entire working class (Lichtenstein 1995).

It is strange, then, that Reuther did not also become more clearly associated in the public mind with a tradition of “war unionism.” For Reuther considered the maximization of defense spending, throughout the Cold War, to be a critical strategic tool for maintaining the labor market power of unskilled production workers (Lichtenstein 1995).¹³ Finally, Reuther considered it strategically worthwhile to try to help maintain job demand by helping the company with its business. This included several strategies, some of which again earned him a reputation as one committed to a radical extension of the union mission, from an allegedly narrow business unionism to a vision, borrowed from the postwar German labor movement, of labor-management co-determination. In practice, this meant that Reuther was frequently found requesting (but rarely establishing) joint labor-management committees for consideration of a large number of production considerations. Co-determination also meant a pledge to help strengthen markets for products, both domestically and abroad. Finally, it meant a controversial series of long-term no-strike pledges, “company security” clauses, and bargaining demands based on a company’s ability to pay. Ultimately, the strategy of industrial unionism became a strategy of caution. Its mission was to cooperate enough to avoid killing the goose that laid the golden egg. As the years passed, companies found themselves in crisis with accelerated frequency, and with each new wage round industrial unionism devolved into concession bargaining, as unemployment hit postwar highs and left industrial unionists without a strategy, unable to achieve strength through increased demand for labor (Moody 1988; Preis 1964).

Moreover, the dream of the industrial unionists, to move beyond the exclusivist tradition in order to embrace the broader working class, met with limited success. Of course, the strategy of union membership shifted from craft logic of strength through restricting membership to an industrial logic of “wall-to-wall” organizing, where union size was a source of prestige. Membership did rise (Galenson 1960). However, membership was not itself a guarantee of market power within the strategic logic of industrial unionism. Rather, within industrial unionism, worker interest in joining unions—which has consistently remained strong—signifies a *will* to power on the part of workers, not a strategy for achieving power.

Membership reached its peak in 1953, and the industrial union movement in the United States never extended beyond the core industries, representing about 34 percent of the workforce during its most successful postwar years (Goldfield 1987). As that percentage stabilized and began to decline, many of the old divisions resurfaced, including significant rebellions of skilled workers within industrial unions and increased emphasis on seniority. Seniority itself operated at the expense of those marginal production workers which the industrial union movement was intended to serve (Lichtenstein 1995). Racial solidarity, always tenuous, deteriorated in many cases, although unionization among blacks and women remains quite strong, especially in the public sector where the corporatist, job-creating efforts were most successful (Aronowitz 1983; Goldfield 1995). As industrial union members, especially in large scale and defense-related industries, came to look increasingly like a labor aristocracy themselves, frequently earning wages several times higher than other area workers, popular support for strikes was undermined. In major industrial disputes, union members were frequently thwarted by the resentment of their own less-fortunate neighbors who—shorn of all pretension and pride—were now willing to undermine the union by becoming strike breakers and replacement workers. Such activities are, as noted from the start of this discussion, the fruit of slack labor markets.¹⁴ So is that it? Is the labor movement left without a viable strategy for labor

market strength? Perhaps not. There is one crucial strategy which has been lost in the logic of industrial unionism: the shorter hours movement.

The shorter hours movement—including the traditional fight for a shorter workday, a shorter workweek, and the struggle against speedups¹⁵—certainly falls within the category of a syndicalist logic of reducing the supply of labor. But its strategic logic is unique in several respects. The logic of solidarity at the heart of the shorter hours movement consists in its maintenance of tight labor markets through the withdrawal of a *portion* of the supply of labor provided by *each person*, rather than through the withdrawal of the *entire* supply of labor provided by a portion of the population of workers. This withdrawal avoids the establishment of exclusivist cleavages within the population, while accomplishing the reduction in labor supply necessary to tighten labor markets.

The shorter hours movement does have a history. Indeed, as an alternative tradition within the syndicalist strategic perspective, the fate of the shorter hours movement sheds a surprising light on conventional assumptions in American labor history. As a bargaining demand, the topic of shorter hours has arisen in diverse camps throughout the last 160 years (Hunnicuttt 1988). Moral reformers and progressives have opposed “excessive” hours as unhealthy, promoting a “normal” workday in order to prevent illness and death from exhaustion. Some communitarians and Jeffersonian democrats have been advocates for family life and political life, respectively, as uplifting alternatives to work life. Conversely, some libertarians and anarchists have seen liberation from the regulated and routinized life of work as the necessary condition for emergence of freedom and the possibilities of diversity, and perversity, in everyday life.

However, within the labor movement itself, the shorter hours movement existed, not simply as a bargaining demand, but as a profound strategy for developing bargaining power. Indeed, throughout the history of the AFL, the movement for shorter hours—while not *overcoming* the AFL’s exclusivist strategies—was the only serious alternative to the exclusivist strategic logics of craft unionism,

nativism, racism, sexism, etc. The leaders of the AFL were strikingly aware of the logic of solidarity that forms the basis of the shorter hours movement (Roediger and Foner 1989). Under the influence of thinkers like Ira Stewart and George McNeill, Samuel Gompers (president of the AFL) became convinced of the logic of the strategy. Indeed, Gompers declared, "According to my own understanding, the eight-hour day was a revolutionary force that altered all the workers' relations, both industrial and social, and raised standards of living and work" (Gompers 1925). Moreover, the infinite applicability of the strategy was also clear. In 1887 Gompers argued, "As long as we have one person seeking work who cannot find it, the hours of work are too long." The movement became one of the most significant elements of AFL strategy and, significantly, had all the appearances of a vital social movement, including rallies, pamphlets, parades, marches, and strikes (Roediger and Foner 1989; Rosenzweig 1983). The logic was clearly articulated by George McNeill in 1888.

Men [sic] who are compelled to sell their labor, very naturally desire to sell the smallest portion of their time for the largest possible price. They are merchants of their time. It is their only available capital. They feel that, if they flood the market,—that is, sell more hours of labor than the market requires,—stagnation will follow.

The growth of the population, greatly enhanced by artificially stimulated emigration from the long-hour and cheap-labor countries of Europe, tends to crowd the streets with unemployed men. Men out of work will underbid the men at work, and so wages are affected and sometimes governed, not by the value of the service rendered in time or skill, but by the number of the unemployed.

The instincts of the wage-workers are wiser than the philosophy of the schools. The demand for less hours of labor for the employed means more hours of work for the now unemployed. It is the demand for a better

distribution of work, as well as a demand for an increase value on each hour's service (McNeill 1887).

The shorter hour movement contested the exclusivist logic of syndicalism as the primary labor strategy within the AFL. The AFL was at its best when it was associated with the movement, and Gompers was himself aware that the prestige of the AFL was enhanced through its association with the popular movement. The fight was also largely successful, with the reduction of the standard workday to ten hours, then eight, and with the introduction of the forty-hour week. The AFL had begun taking bold steps toward the thirty-hour week during the early years of the Depression. William Green, then president of the AFL, was never more bold than when he declared that the AFL was prepared, if need be, to lead a general strike in favor of the thirty-hour week (Roediger and Foner 1989). But the AFL record of success in its prior efforts was not matched by its experience with the thirty-hour fight. What changed? Industrial unionism had emerged on the scene with its new, competing logic of corporatism. A united labor movement had been victorious in its struggles for a shorter workday. But a divided movement, with the hesitant logic of job creation and labor-management cooperation at the heart of industrial unionism, could not triumph. Hillman opposed the AFL-led thirty-hour fight, as did Reuther throughout the postwar era (Fraser 1991; Lichtenstein 1985). While the movement for the shorter workweek continued to have resonance with much of the rank and file, proving to be one of the few issues which gave Reuther factional trouble within the United Automobile Workers (UAW) after his consolidation of power in 1947, it has been largely ignored in the afterglow of postwar industrial union power (Preis 1964).

But the logic remains as strategically sustainable today as ever. In the wake of the corporatist logic of industrial unionism, the shorter hours movement stands out as a neglected strategy, even as neo-exclusivist strategies become more prevalent. The object is not to tighten a portion of the market or tighten the entire market for a portion of the population. Rather, the aim is the tightening of the entire market

for everyone, without necessary regard to skill or identity. The aim is not to imagine communities, but to imagine *increased bargaining power through progressive freedom from work*. The strategic logic becomes particularly clear when the struggle for shorter hours is related to old social movement problems about selective incentives and the logic of collective action (Olson 1965; Gamson 1990). The logic of the shorter hours movement is based upon a win-win strategy, which significantly overcomes the free-rider problem. The old incentive debate within social movement theory is usually understood as a conflict between the partial, self-interested, embodied desires of a single actor, on the one hand, and on the other hand, the need for those interests to be *transcended*, if not sacrificed, to the interests of the collective good. Thus, the development of collective identity and collective sanctions—like shame and moral scorn—are frequently seen as a precondition necessary for the overcoming of “individualism” toward a culture of solidarity and self-sacrifice (Gamson 1990). Indeed, these are common themes within movements for social change.

However, no necessary conflict of this kind emerges within the struggle for shorter hours. At the heart of this movement is a “selective incentive”: less work. Indeed, the demand for less work is unique within our discussion precisely because it is *simultaneously a means to power and a demand of those who have it*. The point is not that “free time” is always necessarily the top demand of workers with the power to make demands. Higher pay, safer working conditions, and so on, are enormously important to workers. Indeed, in our discussion of strategic logics, we have been hitherto concerned primarily with bargaining positions, not bargaining demands. But the demand for better lighting at work, for example, is different from the demand for less work in that better lighting does not help position workers to make other demands. There is no strategic pathway from better lighting to higher pay or less work. But there is a clear *strategic logic* which leads from less work to higher pay, better lighting, and *even less* work. No other bargaining demand simultaneously enhances bargaining position.

Furthermore, no other strategic logic initiates a continuous virtuous cycle in which each victory establishes the conditions for strength in the next struggle. Craft unionism is defeated by the effective struggles of capital to de-skill the labor process. Luddite attempts to maintain skill-based labor processes may meet with some successes, but they represent an uphill battle on a steep incline. Industrial unionism is weakened by its own dependence on capital's increasingly feeble commitment to a "job pact." Rather than preserving jobs, capitalists have struggled in the postwar era to break union pretensions through the introduction of labor-saving (thus, job-destroying) technologies.

In contrast to the difficulties of craft and industrial unions, the movement for shorter hours does not anticipate or depend upon a corporatist truce in the dynamics of class struggle. It has no need to fear its own victories, nor be cautious in its approach. The strategic logic of the shorter hours movement is capable of anticipating and ongoing progressive and dynamic struggle. In this struggle, shorter hours tighten labor markets. Tight labor markets drive up labor costs. High labor costs generate capitalist efforts to reduce labor costs through automation, computerization, and work reorganization. Further reduction in hours further tightens labor markets. On and on it may go.

With a strategic logic capable of embracing the entire working class and a sustainability capable of responding to capitalist offenses, the shorter hours movement is strategically capable of sustained industrial class struggle in ways that the revolutionary socialist tradition, for example, has never imagined. The strategic logic of the shorter hours movement does not aim to end class struggle or create of a world in which labor rules itself. Rather, it is a movement to persist and prosper through class struggle, as its dynamic yields a harvest of opulence and ease through the progressive struggle for the liberation from work itself.

Some of the essays that follow were first presented at a conference titled "The Wages of Cybernation" sponsored by the Center for Cultural Studies at the Graduate Center of the City University of New York. Others have been written

expressly for this volume. The conference itself would not have been possible without the efforts and support of Mae Ngai, Joe McDermott, Kristin Lawler, Mike Roberts, and Mark Halling.

The essays in this book are directed to helping us to better understand the nature of various economic and political changes underway, their consequences, and what labor and other social movements might do about them.

After this introduction, "The Post-Work Manifesto" leads the volume with a critique of contemporary economic trends and a call to action. The manifesto concludes with a program that may infuse many social movements as we edge toward the millenium. Michael Lewis, William DiFazio, and Lynn Chancer discuss poverty, welfare policy and the guaranteed income. Lewis argues for income as a moral right; based on years of work in a Bedford-Stuyvestant soup kitchen, DiFazio's long ethnographic and theoretical study of poverty helps explain why there is no movement of the poor in America; and Chancer's essay is an extended analysis of guaranteed income proposals that have from time to time engaged social policy. Lois Weiner discusses the education to work controversy; Stanley Aronowitz asks why the professoriat is under attack and tenure has become a target of university administrations. Joan Greenbaum, whose work on computerization has attracted worldwide attention, explores one of the crucial aspects of the current economic debate, the impact of computers in the white-collar workplace. The final two essays reflect an attempt, initiated by the organizers of the "Wages of Cybernation" conference, to fuse the discourses of political economy and cultural radicalism. In his essay, Andrew Parker argues that it is impossible to bridge the divide which separates these two discourses without first challenging the cultural productivism and workerism of the Marxist left. Social and cultural critic Ellen Willis contributes a piece on the logic of austerity in an effort to understand how cultural conservatism and economic austerity are mutually reinforcing. If worktime is simultaneously a locus of capitalist exploitation *and* cultural discipline, then it is definitely *quitting time*.